Art or Artifact

Five steps with guiding questions to help you understand and analyze the primary source

1 **Identify the Source**	When was this piece of art or artifact (a historical object) created?
	Where was it created?
	Who created it?
2 **Place the Source in Context**	What's the historical context of this piece of art or artifact?
	Was it created for purposes of entertainment or aesthetics? Or is it something functional?
	Are there markings or other indications of its origin?
3 **Analyze the Source Content**	If this is a piece of art, what does it portray?
	If this is an artifact, what was its purpose?
4 **Assess the Source Perspective**	If this is a piece of art, what medium did the artist use to express herself or himself?
	If this is a piece of art, what biases or perspectives did the artist have?
	Was the creator trying to motivate or convince people?
	If this is an artifact, what do you think were the reasons for its creation and use?
	If this is an artifact, what does it tell you about the individual and society who created it?
5 **Evaluate the Source**	If this is a piece of art, how do you think viewers reacted to it? How do you react to it?
	If this is an artifact, do you think it was a useful one? How so?
	Why was this art or artifact important to the people who created and used it, and why is it important now for what it can tell us?
	What connections can you make from it to politics, issues, culture and society, faith and religion, and historical change over time?
	Does comparing this art or artifact with other sources, past or present, provide valuable insight?
	Can you tie this art or artifact into key themes, questions, controversies, and debates?

Audio

Five steps with guiding questions to help you understand and analyze the primary source

1 **Identify the Source**	When was this audio recording made?
	Where was this audio recording made?
	Who made this audio recording? Was it taken by an amateur sound recorder or a professional?
2 **Place the Source in Context**	What's the historical context of this audio recording?
	Who can you identify speaking in the audio recording? Are there other sounds besides talking?
	Is there an introduction or narration accompanying this audio recording?
3 **Analyze the Source Content**	Who or what is the subject of this audio recording?
	Is the audio of an event, an interview, or something else?
	Does the audio record something that happened as part of a normal course of events, or was the audio artificially recorded or set up by someone?
4 **Assess the Source Perspective**	Does the audio record how something sounded, or does it "tell a story" by what it includes?
	If the audio recording is "telling a story," what is that story? Is there a particular perspective on the part of the sound recorder or the subject of the audio recording?
	Was the audio recorder trying to convey or capture a particular mood?
	Is there a particular historical or social background to the audio recording?
	How do you think viewers would react to the audio recording? Would everyone have the same reaction?
5 **Evaluate the Source**	Do you think this is an effective or useful audio recording?
	Why was this audio recording important at the time it was made, and why is important now for what it can tell us?
	What connections can you make from this audio recording to politics, issues, culture and society, faith and religion, and historical change over time?
	Does comparing this audio recording with other sources, past or present, provide valuable insight?
	Can you tie this audio recording into key themes, questions, controversies, and debates?

Cartoon

Five steps with guiding questions to help you understand and analyze the primary source

1 **Identify the Source**	When was this cartoon created?
	Where was this cartoon created?
	What publication ran the cartoon?
2 **Place the Source in Context**	What is the historical context of this cartoon?
	What people, objects, or other elements can you identify in the cartoon?
	What is the message or opinion relayed in the cartoon?
	What makes the cartoon funny or insightful or critical?
3 **Analyze the Source Content**	What is happening in the cartoon?
	What is the message or opinion relayed in the cartoon?
	Who or what does the cartoon target?
	What makes the cartoon funny or insightful or critical?
4 **Assess the Source Perspective**	How does the creator of the cartoon convey information and make a point?
	Does the cartoon have a particular bias or perspective?
	Does the creator try to motivate or convince people using this cartoon? If so, how?
	How do you think viewers reacted to the cartoon?
5 **Evaluate the Source**	Do you think this cartoon is an effective one? Did it amuse people or make them think?
	Why was this cartoon important to the people who created and viewed it, and why is important now for what it can tell us?
	What connections can you make from this cartoon to politics, issues, culture and society, faith and religion, and historical change over time?
	Does comparing this cartoon with other sources, past or present, provide valuable insight?
	How can you tie this cartoon into key themes, questions, controversies, and debates?

Government or Legal Document

Five steps with guiding questions to help you understand and analyze the primary source

1 **Identify the Source**	When and where was this document created?
	What branch of government or authority created this document?
	Who wrote the document and what authority does that person or institution have?
2 **Place the Source in Context**	Who is the intended audience for this document?
	What kind of document is it? Legislation, verdict, treaty, proclamation, or something else? How was it distributed?
	What's the historical context of this document? What is the background or reason for it?
	Was the creation of this document an unusual event, or something done regularly?
	What is the subject of this document? What issue or issues does it address?
3 **Analyze the Source Content**	Is this the first document of this type or on this issue?
	What does this document order, or what does it prohibit, if anything?
	Does this document have a particular perspective or bias?
4 **Assess the Source Perspective**	Does this document take sides with one or another political or social party or group with a certain point-of-view?
	What type of language is used in this document? Is it administrative or motivational? How do you think people reacted to it?
	Do you think this document is an effective one?
5 **Evaluate the Source**	Why was this document important to the people or institution who issued it, and why is important now for what it can tell us?
	What connections can you make from this document to politics, issues, culture and society, faith and religion, historical change over time, etc.?
	Does comparing this document with other sources, past or present, provide valuable insight?
	How can you tie this document into key themes, questions, controversies, and debates?

Letter or Telegram

Five steps with guiding questions to help you understand and analyze the primary source

1 **Identify the Source**	Who wrote this letter?
	Who received this letter? Was there one recipient or multiple recipients?
	When was this letter sent and received?
	Where was this letter written?
	How was this letter sent? Did it go to the correct recipient?
2 **Place the Source in Context**	What's the historical context of this letter? What is the background or reason for it?
	Why was this message conveyed by a letter?
	Was this a formal or informal letter? Personal, political, administrative?
	Was this letter something unusual, or something sent regularly?
3 **Analyze the Source Content**	What is the subject of the letter?
	What is the letter's central message?
	Is the author making an inquiry? Does the author expect a reply?
4 **Assess the Source Perspective**	How does the author convey information and make a point?
	What is the tone of the letter?
	Is the author advocating a certain action (or inaction)?
	Does the author have a particular bias or perspective?
	Does the author try to motivate or convince the recipient? If so, how?
	How do you think the recipient or recipients reacted to the letter?
5 **Evaluate the Source**	Do you think this letter is an effective one?
	Why was this letter important to the people who wrote and received it, and why is important now for what it can tell us?
	What connections can you make from this letter to politics, issues, culture and society, faith and religion, historical change over time, etc.?
	Does comparing this letter with other sources, past or present, provide valuable insight?
	How can you tie this letter into key themes, questions, controversies, and debates?

Map

Five steps with guiding questions to help you understand and analyze the primary source

1 **Identify the Source**	Who created this map?
	What kind of map is it? Topographic, political, military, economic, population, satellite, or something else?
2 **Place the Source in Context**	What's the historical context of this map?
	When was the map made, and what time or era does the map show?
3 **Analyze the Source Content**	What does this map show?
	Does the map include a legend or guide?
	What facts does the map include?
	Does this map have a particular subject?
	Does the map show a change over time or differences among regions?
4 **Assess the Source Perspective**	Does the data in the map suggest certain conclusions?
	Does this map directly or indirectly have a specific point or perspective?
	Does the map support or contradict your own conclusions?
	Do you think the map is accurate?
	Does the map include everything you would like to see? What do you think might make it better?
5 **Evaluate the Source**	Do you think this map is an important one? Why do you think it was created?
	What conclusions does this map lead you to make?
	What connections can you make from this map to politics, issues, culture and society, faith and religion, historical change over time, etc.?
	Does comparing this map with other sources, past or present, provide valuable insight?
	Can you tie this map into key themes, questions, controversies, and debates? How can you tie this map into questions you have?

Newspaper

Five steps with guiding questions to help you understand and analyze the primary source

1 **Identify the Source**	What newspaper published this article? Who wrote it?
	When and where was this article published?
	Who do you think the readers were?
2 **Place the Source in Context**	What's the historical context of this article? What is the background or reason for it?
	What event or story is this article covering?
	What made this story newsworthy of publication in the newspaper?
3 **Analyze the Source Content**	Is this a news article or an editorial?
	What is the subject of the article?
	What is the story's primary point?
4 **Assess the Source Perspective**	If this is a news article, does it seem to be objective, or does it contain some bias or perspective?
	If this is an editorial or opinion piece, what perspective does the author have?
	If this is an editorial or opinion piece, how does the author try to motivate or convince the reader?
	Is the article's coverage thorough? Do you think anything was left out?
	How do you think readers reacted to the article?
5 **Evaluate the Source**	Do you think this document is an effective one?
	Why is this article important? Why was it important to the people who read it, and why is important now for what it can tell us?
	What connections can you make from this article to politics, issues, culture and society, faith and religion, historical change over time, etc.?
	Does comparing this article with other sources, past or present, provide valuable insight?
	How can you tie this article into key themes, questions, controversies, and debates?

Oral History

Five steps with guiding questions to help you understand and analyze the primary source

1 Identify the Source	When was this oral history created?
	Where was this oral history created?
	Who created or sponsored the oral history?
2 Place the Source in Context	What is the historical context for this oral history? What is the background or reason for it?
	Is there an introduction or narration accompanying this oral history? Are there images or music?
3 Analyze the Source Content	Who is the subject of this oral history?
	What is the story the speaker is conveying? What is the speaker's central message?
	What type of language does the speaker use?
4 Assess the Source Perspective	Does the speaker have a particular bias or perspective?
	What do you think the speaker hoped to accomplish with the oral history?
	How do you think viewers would react to the oral history? Would everyone have the same reaction?
5 Evaluate the Source	Why was this oral history important at the time it was created, and why is it important now for what it can tell us?
	Does comparing this oral history with other sources, past or present, provide valuable insight?
	How can you tie this oral history into key themes, questions, controversies, and debates?

Photograph

Five steps with guiding questions to help you understand and analyze the primary source

1 **Identify the Source**	When was this photograph taken?
	Where was this photograph taken?
	Who took the photograph? Was it taken by an amateur photographer, a professional, or by a satellite?
2 **Place the Source in Context**	What's the historical context of this photograph?
	What people, objects, or other elements can you identify in the photograph?
	Is there a caption or other notes that provide you with additional data?
3 **Analyze the Source Content**	Who or what is the subject of this photograph?
	Is the photo of an event, a portrait, or something else?
	Does the photo show something that happened as part of a normal course of events, or was the photo artificially arranged by the photographer?
4 **Assess the Source Perspective**	If this is a portrait, how does the photographer portray the subject?
	Does the photograph document how something looked, or does it "tell a story" by what it includes?
	If the photograph is "telling a story," what is that story? Is there a particular perspective on the part of the photographer or the subject of the photograph?
	Was the photographer tying to convey or capture a particular mood?
	Is there a particular historical or social background to the photograph?
	How do you think viewers would react to the photograph? Would everyone have the same reaction?
5 **Evaluate the Source**	Do you think this is an effective photograph?
	Why was this photograph important at the time it was taken, and why is important now for what it can tell us?
	What connections can you make from this photograph to politics, issues, culture and society, faith and religion, and historical change over time?
	Does comparing this photograph with other sources, past or present, provide valuable insight?
	Can you tie this photograph into key themes, questions, controversies, and debates?

Speech

Five steps with guiding questions to help you understand and analyze the primary source

1 **Identify the Source**	Who delivered this speech?
	When was this speech made?
	Where was this speech made? What was the setting?
	What was the occasion for this speech?
2 **Place the Source in Context**	What's the historical context of this speech? What is the background or reason for it?
	Who would have been hearing this speech? What expectations would they have had?
	Was this a formal or informal speech?
	Was this speech an unusual event, or something done regularly?
3 **Analyze the Source Content**	What is the subject of the speech?
	What is the speaker's central message?
	What type of language does the speaker use?
4 **Assess the Source Perspective**	How does the speaker convey information and make a point?
	What is the tone of the speech?
	Is the speaker advocating a certain action (or inaction?)
	Does the speaker have a particular bias or perspective?
	How does the speaker try to motivate or convince people using this poster?
	How do you think listeners reacted to the speech?
5 **Evaluate the Source**	Do you think this speech is an effective one?
	Why is this speech important? Why was it important to the people who heard it, and why is important now for what it can tell us?
	What connections can you make from this speech to politics, issues, culture and society, faith and religion, historical change over time, etc.?
	Does comparing this speech with other sources, past or present, provide valuable insight?
	How can you tie this speech into key themes, questions, controversies, and debates?

Statistics

Five steps with guiding questions to help you understand and analyze the primary source

1 **Identify the Source**	Who created these statistics? What is the source?
	What type of statistics are they? Charts, graphs, tables, or something else?
2 **Place the Source in Context**	What is the historical context for these statistics?
	What time, place, and topic or topics do these statistics cover?
3 **Analyze the Source Content**	What do these statistics reveal? What conclusions can you draw by analyzing the data?
	Do these statistics show a change over time or difference across regions or differences across other subjects?
	Do these statistics include a guide or commentary to help you interpret them?
4 **Assess the Source Perspective**	Do you think the compiler of these statistics had a particular perspective or bias?
	Do you think these statistics are accurate?
	Do these statistics support or contradict your own conclusions?
5 **Evaluate the Source**	What can you learn by analyzing the data in these statistics?
	Do you think these statistics are useful? Are they important?
	What connections can you make from these statistics to politics, issues, culture and society, faith and religion, historical change over time, etc.?
	How can you connect these statistics into key themes, questions, controversies, and debates? How can you connect these statistics into questions you have?

Video

Five steps with guiding questions to help you understand and analyze the primary source

1 **Identify the Source**	When was this video made?
	Where was this video made?
	Who took the video? Was it taken by an amateur videographer, a professional, or by a satellite?
2 **Place the Source in Context**	What's the historical context of this video?
	What people, objects, or other elements can you identify in the video?
	Is there narration that provides you with additional information?
3 **Analyze the Source Content**	Who or what is the subject of this video?
	Is the video of an event, a person, or something else?
	Does the video show something that happened as part of a normal course of events, or was the video artificially arranged by the videographer?
4 **Assess the Source Perspective**	Does the video show how something looked, or does it "tell a story" by what it includes?
	If the video is "telling a story," what is that story? Is there a particular perspective on the part of the videographer or the subject of the video?
	Was the videographer trying to convey or capture a particular mood?
	Is there a particular historical or social background to the video?
	How do you think viewers would react to the video? Would everyone have the same reaction?
5 **Evaluate the Source**	Do you think this is an effective video?
	Why was this video important at the time it was made, and why is important now for what it can tell us?
	What connections can you make from this video to politics, issues, culture and society, faith and religion, and historical change over time?
	Does comparing this video with other sources, past or present, provide valuable insight?
	Can you tie this video into key themes, questions, controversies, and debates?

Written Document

Five steps with guiding questions to help you understand and analyze the primary source

1 **Identify the Source**	When was this document created?
	Where was it created?
	Who wrote the document?
2 **Place the Source in Context**	What was the historical context for this document? Is it associated with an event or movement?
	Who was the intended audience for this document?
	What kind of document is it? How would you categorize it?
	How was this document distributed? Was there one copy made, or many copies?
	Was the creation of this document an unusual event, or something done regularly?
3 **Analyze the Source Content**	What is the subject of this document? What issue or issues does it address? What information is conveyed?
	What arguments does the author or authors of this document make?
4 **Assess the Source Perspective**	Does this document have a particular perspective or bias?
	What type of language is used in this document?
	How do you think people at the time reacted to this document?
5 **Evaluate the Source**	Do you think this document is an effective one?
	Why is this document important? Why was it important to the people or institution who created it, and why is important now for what it can tell us?
	What connections can you make from this document to politics, issues, culture and society, faith and religion, historical change over time, etc.?
	Does comparing this document with other sources, past or present, provide valuable insight?
	How can you tie this document into key themes, questions, controversies, and debates?